



FOR FIRST TIME DADS — FREE GUIDE FROM DUDELA

15 THINGS EVERY DAD SHOULD DO BEFORE THE BABY ARRIVES

*Most first-time dads aren't unprepared because they don't care.
They're unprepared because nobody told them what to focus on.*

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Let's be honest.

Nobody handed you a playbook when you found out you were going to be a dad. The internet gives you a thousand checklists for the nursery and exactly zero guidance on what *you* actually need to do — emotionally, financially, practically, and in that delivery room.

Most first-time dads aren't unprepared because they don't care. They're unprepared because nobody told them what to focus on. This is that list.

These 15 things come straight from our own experiences — John's high-risk Mo-Di twin pregnancy (34 weeks, NICU for a month) and Mike's emergency C-section when the birth plan changed in 90 seconds flat. We also drew from every dad we've coached and every conversation we've had on the podcast.

Use it like this: read through once to get the full picture, then go section by section and check things off as you do them. The conversation starters are meant to actually be used with your partner — 20 minutes, no phones, and actually do them.

The Dudela Prep Kit goes 5x deeper into every one of these areas — real stories, expert commentary, and complete frameworks. You'll know when you're ready for it. thedudelaco.com

Get Your Head Right

You're going through something too. The pressure, the fear, the quiet grief of a life that's about to change forever — dads feel all of it. The ones who handle it best aren't the ones who stuff it down. They're the ones who built a practice for managing it before things got intense.



Do the one-word daily check-in.

Every evening, write down one word for how you're feeling. Not a journal. One word. Anxious. Excited. Overwhelmed. Grateful. This builds the self-awareness that makes you steady when everything gets intense. It takes 10 seconds and it works.



Name your biggest stress — out loud.

Write down the one thing you're most anxious about right now. Then say it to your partner. 'I've been stressed about [X]' is intimacy. Silence is distance. The moment you name a fear, it gets smaller. Try it this week.



Build your reset routine before you need it.

What helps you discharge stress? A 20-minute walk. A workout. 10 quiet minutes outside without your phone. Figure out your one thing and do it consistently between now and baby's arrival. Your nervous system needs practice, not just good intentions at 2am.



Have one honest conversation with another dad.

Not to get advice. Not to solve anything. Just to say it out loud to someone who gets it. 'I'm nervous. I don't feel ready. I'm not sure what I'm doing.' The isolation of 'I'm fine' is one of the biggest traps for expecting dads. One real conversation changes everything.

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

→ "What have you been most stressed about lately? I want to actually know."

→ "What do you need from me emotionally right now — not what you think I can handle. What you actually need."

→ "Is there anything I've been doing that's made this harder for you?"

DUDELA RECOMMENDS

The Intentional Father — Jon Tyson

About the dad you want to become — not the one you'll end up being by default. Read it before baby arrives.

The Dudela Podcast — thedudelaco.com

Episodes on the emotional side of fatherhood, postpartum dads, and what nobody tells you about your mental state in those first weeks home.

Get Your Money Ready

Money stress is one of the top reasons new parents fight. Not because they don't love each other — because they waited until week 38 to look at the actual numbers together. Mike and Abigail did exactly that. Don't repeat that mistake. Twenty minutes with a spreadsheet in week 30 is worth ten times more than the same conversation after you haven't slept in three days.



Map your parental leave — both of you, on paper, this week.

How many weeks of paid leave does she have? You? When does her pay stop or change? What's the income gap? Write the actual numbers. If you have parental leave available — take it. Even 2 weeks makes a material difference in those early days. Don't leave it on the table because you feel guilty using it.



Build the new monthly budget with baby expenses included.

Add real estimates for: childcare/daycare, diapers and formula, health insurance changes, baby gear, pediatric visits, and an emergency fund contribution. Run the number. Knowing is always better than guessing — even if the number is uncomfortable.



Handle the three basics: life insurance, your will, and your health deductible.

Life insurance: if you don't have term life, get a quote today — it's inexpensive when you're young and healthy and it's not optional anymore. Will: update your beneficiaries. Health insurance: call your provider and ask what you'll owe for delivery. Some families are shocked by thousands of dollars on day one.

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

- "Let's look at the actual numbers together — not to stress about it, just to know where we stand."
- "What's your honest gut feeling about money right now? What would make you feel better?"
- "If I took one financial task completely off your plate before baby arrives, what would it be?"

DUDELA RECOMMENDS

The Family Board Meeting — Jim Sheils

Short book. Treat your family with the same intentionality you bring to work. Read it before the baby comes.

Your employer's HR portal — log in this week

Check FSA enrollment, parental leave policy, and your health plan's delivery deductible. Most dads never do this until it's too late.

Be The Partner She Needs

You're not the assistant. You're the co-pilot. Active partnership doesn't start when the baby comes home — it starts right now. The third trimester is physically brutal for most women: sleep is broken, her body feels foreign, anxiety is peaking, and the mental load of preparing for all of this has been building for months.

- ☐ **Take three things off her plate this week — without announcing it.**
Don't say 'I'm going to do [thing] for you.' Just do it. Groceries. Dishes. Laundry. Researching pediatricians. Every time she doesn't have to manage you on top of everything else, you've done something real. Look around. Notice what needs to happen. Do it.
- ☐ **Ask her directly: 'What would actually help most right now?' Then do that exact thing.**
What worked before might be different now. Her needs in week 34 aren't what they were in week 20. Ask the question, listen to the answer, and then do the specific thing she said — not the thing you think she should need.
- ☐ **Research, pack, and own the hospital bag before week 36.**
Take this completely off her list. Look it up, make the list, gather the items, pack it. Include a Dad Bag for yourself: phone charger, snacks, change of clothes, toiletries. Labor can run 12+ hours. Being comfortable means you can stay present instead of distracted.
- ☐ **Go through the birth plan together. Know it cold.**
Know her preferences — pain management, who's in the room, cord clamping, skin-to-skin, what to do if things change fast. In the delivery room, if she's mid-contraction and a nurse needs an answer, you give it. You hold the plan. Make the plan. Know it cold. Then be ready to let it go and just be there.

"The birth plan isn't about everything going perfectly. It's about both of you knowing what matters — so when things shift, you're still operating from the same page." — Mike, after Riley's emergency C-section

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

- "Walk me through your ideal birth experience. I want to be ready to advocate for it."
- "What are you most nervous about for labor? What would help you feel more prepared?"
- "What do you want the first week home to look like — who's there, when, and for how long?"

DUDELA RECOMMENDS

Taking Cara Babies — takingcarababies.com

The single best resource we've found for newborn sleep. John's twins were sleeping through the night by month two. If you want to function as a partner and a dad in those early months, figure out sleep first.

Hunt Gather Parent — Michaelleen Doucleff

Completely shifts how you think about partnering in parenting. Eye-opening look at how other cultures raise kids with far less friction than the Western default.

We're an affiliate partner with Taking Cara Babies — if you sign up through the link above, we may earn a small commission at no extra cost to you.

Know What You're Walking Into

You don't need to become a medical professional. You need to know enough to ask good questions, understand the answers, and advocate for your partner when it matters most. Hospitals move fast. Decisions get made in moments. She may be in too much pain to process what's being said. That's your job.



Learn the kick count protocol and the warning signs that require an immediate call.

After 28 weeks: at least 10 movements in 2 hours. Know the baseline. Decreased movement is one of the first signs something's off. Also know these cold — heavy bleeding, contractions before 37 weeks that intensify, severe headache or vision changes, signs of water breaking. Save your OB's after-hours number in your phone right now.



Learn the BRAIN framework. Use it every time something unexpected comes up.

When the medical team recommends something you didn't plan for, don't just nod. Use this five-letter framework to slow the moment down and ask one good question:

B
Benefits

What are the benefits of this recommendation?

R
Risks

What are the risks?

A
Alternatives

Are there other options we should consider?

I
Intuition

What does her gut say?

N
Nothing

What happens if we wait or do nothing right now?

You're not being difficult. You're being responsible. Good medical teams expect informed partners. It's okay to ask for a minute. It's okay to ask a question twice.

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

→ "At our next OB appointment, let's make a list of questions together beforehand."

→ "What's something about labor or delivery you want me to be specifically ready for?"

→ "If something unexpected happens in the delivery room, what do you want me to do first?"

DUDELA RECOMMENDS

The Birth Partner — Penny Simkin

The most practical book on labor support for partners. What to expect, what to do, what to say, hour by hour. If you read one book on delivery, make it this.

Take a childbirth class — any class

Online or in-person. Lamaze, Bradley, hospital-based — all valuable. You'll walk into the delivery room with context, vocabulary, and significantly less panic. Ask your OB for a recommendation at the next appointment.

Decide What Kind of Dad You Want to Be

This is the one most guides skip — because it's harder to put on a checklist. But the dads who navigate fatherhood best aren't the ones who had the easiest pregnancies or the smoothest deliveries. They're the ones who got intentional about this before baby arrived. Who do you want to be?

- ☐ **Write down the answer to this: 'When my kid is 8, what do I want them to say about their dad?'**
Not 'a good provider.' Specifically. 'He was always there when I needed him.' 'He stayed calm when things went wrong.' 'He made me feel safe.' 'He was present.' Write it down. Somewhere you'll see it. This becomes your compass for every decision that feels hard later — and there will be a lot of those decisions.
- ☐ **Have the family values conversation with your partner before week 36.**
You don't need a laminated family manifesto. You need a shared sense of what matters. What does success look like for a kid in your family? How do you handle conflict? What do you want your home to feel like? Twenty minutes on the couch, week 34. Mike and Abigail did this. It became the reference point they return to whenever they're not sure what to do.

THREE QUESTIONS WORTH SITTING WITH

1. What's one thing your dad did that you want to replicate?
2. What's one thing you want to do differently?
3. What's one thing you never got that you want to make sure your kid gets?

Take 20 minutes. No phone. Write actual answers. This is the work that separates intentional dads from accidental ones.

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

- "What kind of home do we want to build — not the house, the feeling?"
- "What's something about how you were raised that you really want to carry forward?"
- "What's one thing we want to protect about us — even after baby comes?"

You're more ready than you think.

Nobody walks into fatherhood completely ready. That's not the goal. The goal is to show up with intention — head in the right place, finances sorted, an active partner, informed enough to advocate, and clear on who you want to be.

That's what these 15 things build toward. Keep the list. Come back to it. Check things off as you go. And when baby arrives — trust yourself. You did the work.

One last thing from John:

The moment they put my daughters in my arms, I didn't feel some mystical wave of instant perfection. I felt terrified and overwhelmed and I had no idea what I was doing. I also felt more purposeful than I'd ever felt in my life. Those two things coexisted. They still do. That's the job. And it's worth it.

One last thing from Mike:

My daughter Riley is going to know me as her dad for the rest of her life. That's the longest relationship I'll have with another person. I try to make decisions from that perspective — not from the 2am exhaustion or the bad day at work. From the long view. From the person I want her to know I was.

WANT TO GO DEEPER?

The Dudela Prep Kit

Our full guide goes 5x deeper into every section — real stories, frameworks, expert commentary from Abigail Colander (Special Education & Emotional Regulation Specialist), and a complete system from the third trimester through the first weeks home.

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